

## **Briefing V — Paris: The City of Light**

### *First Impressions: Paris from Above*

Our journey now takes us from the quiet villages and battlefields of Normandy to one of the world's great cities.

Paris.

After settling into our apartment and taking just enough time to catch our breath, we'll head to our very first destination.

The Arc de Triomphe.

Tonight, it will become our introduction to Paris.

Commissioned by Napoleon after his victory at Austerlitz, the Arc was built to honor the soldiers who fought for France. Over the past two centuries it has become far more than a military monument. It has witnessed victory parades, the funeral procession of Victor Hugo, the liberation of Paris in 1944, and today shelters the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier beneath its great arch. There are few places that better symbolize the history and spirit of France.

There are many wonderful ways to experience Paris for the first time.

This may be my favorite.

Rather than beginning at street level, we'll begin high above the city.

The climb to the top is well worth the effort.

As we step onto the observation deck, Paris will suddenly unfold in every direction.

The Eiffel Tower rises to the southwest.

The white dome of Sacré-Cœur crowns Montmartre in the distance.

La Défense marks the modern skyline beyond.

The Seine winds gracefully through the heart of the city.

And stretching outward beneath us are twelve magnificent avenues radiating from the Arc like the spokes of a wheel.

Take a moment before reaching for your camera.

Simply look.

Notice how remarkably consistent the city appears.

The elegant limestone buildings.

The broad boulevards.

The church towers and domes rising above the rooftops.

The surprising absence of skyscrapers.

Much of what we're seeing is the result of one of the most ambitious urban transformations in history.

As we covered in Briefing II, in the mid-1800s, under Emperor Napoleon III and the direction of Baron Haussmann, Paris was reimagined with wide boulevards, beautiful parks, modern sewers, gas lighting, and a striking architectural consistency that cities around the world would later try to emulate.

You'll see echoes of these ideas back home—in New York's great parks, in Chicago's grand civic planning, and in Washington's monumental avenues—but nowhere do they come together quite like they do here.

As the sun begins to set, the city slowly changes.

The warm light catches the limestone facades.

The monuments begin to glow.

Streetlights flicker on.

The energy below shifts from the workday to the evening.

It's one of my favorite moments in Paris.

Not because we've seen everything.

But because, from this single vantage point, we begin to understand the city we'll spend the next several days exploring.

In just a few minutes, we'll descend the stairs and become part of it ourselves.

We'll trade the panoramic view for neighborhood streets.

The grand boulevards for quiet cafés.

The skyline for the sidewalks.

Our adventure in Paris is about to begin.

*Learning to See Paris*

Over the next few days, we'll visit some of the most famous places in the world.

The Eiffel Tower.

Notre-Dame.

The Louvre.

The Seine.

But I'd encourage everyone not to spend the entire trip looking only for famous landmarks.

Instead, look for the city between them.

Some of my favorite moments in Paris have happened while simply walking from one destination to the next.

A quiet side street.

A neighborhood market.

An elderly couple sharing lunch at a café.

Children sailing toy boats in a garden fountain.

A violinist playing beneath a bridge.

Paris rewards people who pay attention.

One of the first things you'll notice is the remarkable consistency of the city.

The buildings seem to belong together.

The streets feel intentional.

Even the apartment balconies and rooftops seem to follow the same rhythm.

It's one of the reasons Paris feels so elegant.

As we discussed in Briefing II, much of that is thanks to the remarkable transformation of the city under Napoleon III and Baron Haussmann during the nineteenth century.

You don't need to remember all the details.

Just remember to look for the result.

The broad boulevards.

The rows of honey-colored limestone buildings.

The tree-lined avenues.

The parks.

The grand vistas that seem to end with a monument almost everywhere you look.

You'll also notice that Paris doesn't compete with its history.

It lives alongside it.

A neighborhood bakery may occupy a building that's older than the United States.

A café terrace may sit in the shadow of a church that has stood for centuries.

A walk through the city might take you past Roman ruins, medieval churches, Renaissance courtyards, and nineteenth-century boulevards—all within a few blocks.

Rather than replacing the old with the new, Paris has a remarkable way of layering one generation upon another.

As you explore, remember to look up.

Some of the city's greatest treasures aren't at eye level.

Beautiful iron balconies.

Stone carvings above doorways.

Hidden courtyards.

Clock towers.

Domes.

And rooftops stretching toward the horizon.

Now I have a challenge for the kids...

...and honestly, I think the adults should play along too.

Let's call it **The Paris Challenge**.

Over the next few days, see how many little treasures you can discover that aren't on our itinerary.

Can you find...

- the best-smelling bakery?

- the tiniest street?
- the prettiest flower box?
- an interesting gargoyle?
- a street musician?
- a funny shop sign?
- a beautiful old doorway?
- a neighborhood playground?
- someone walking a very French-looking dog?
- a café where it looks like everyone knows one another?
- your favorite window to peek into?
- the prettiest little courtyard?
- the best view that wasn't in a guidebook?

You don't have to find everything.

In fact, you'll probably discover things that aren't on this list at all.

That's even better.

By the time we leave Paris, I don't want each of you to tell me your favorite landmark.

I want you to tell me about your favorite discovery.

Something that wasn't on our itinerary.

Because those unexpected discoveries are often the moments that stay with us the longest.

*Living Like a Parisian*

One of the wonderful things about Paris is that it doesn't ask you to do very much.

It simply invites you to slow down.

Unlike some cities that seem to reward constant motion, Paris rewards lingering.

Sit at the café a little longer.

Walk the longer route home.

Browse the bookstore you hadn't planned to enter.

Stop to listen to the violinist for another minute.

The city isn't going anywhere.

One of the reasons Kate and I have always enjoyed coming back is that we've experienced Paris in different ways over the years.

Kate spent a semester here during her junior year of college, so she knows what it's like to experience Paris not as a tourist, but as a temporary resident. She shopped at neighborhood markets, learned her way around the Métro, found favorite cafés, and built everyday routines.

One of my favorite memories came a few years later, when I surprised Kate with a trip back to Paris for our first anniversary. It was my first time experiencing the city with her, and instead of showing me only the famous sights, she introduced me to many of the quiet squares, neighborhood streets, and favorite corners she had discovered while living here. It reminded me that every city has two versions—the one in the guidebooks and the one that belongs to the people who know it well. Ever since then, that's the Paris I've tried to find whenever I've returned.

I've been fortunate enough to visit Paris several other times myself.

One of my earliest visits came during one of my very first business trips after joining THL.

I wandered into Hermès looking for something special to bring home for Kate and walked out with a beautiful scarf that, at the time, felt like it had cost my entire bank account.

Looking back, I remember being far more excited to give it to her than I was worried about paying the credit card bill.

That's one of the funny things about travel.

Years later, you rarely remember exactly what something cost.

You remember where you were when you found it.

Paris has a wonderful food culture, but not every memorable meal has to last three hours.

One of my favorite traditions is stopping for a *croque monsieur* from a street vendor—a warm grilled ham and cheese sandwich that's one of France's great comfort foods.

Years ago, when my French was even worse than it is today, I started a running joke with Kate that continues to this day. Rather than attempting to pronounce *croque monsieur*, I'd simply announce that I was going to get a "Mr. Sandwich." It was my way of poking fun at my own terrible French, and somehow the nickname stuck.

So if someone decides to order a croque monsieur during the trip, you'll know exactly why I'll be smiling.

As we explore the city, you'll notice something else.

Parisians don't seem to be in a hurry to get anywhere.

The cafés aren't simply places to eat.

They're places to talk.

To read.

To watch the world go by.

You'll notice that many of the chairs face outward toward the street instead of toward one another.

The entertainment is the city itself.

Watching people.

Listening to conversations drift past.

Feeling the rhythm of everyday life.

Now, I should probably admit something.

Our itinerary isn't exactly the Parisian ideal.

We're going to be walking a lot.

Seeing a lot.

And trying to squeeze an incredible amount into just a few days.

That's okay.

The goal isn't to pretend we're Parisians.

The goal is simply to borrow a few of their habits while we're here.

Maybe we linger over lunch for an extra fifteen minutes.

Maybe we stop to listen to the street musician instead of hurrying past.

Maybe we pause on a bridge over the Seine instead of rushing to the next stop.

Maybe we take the longer walk home because it's prettier.

Those little moments won't keep us from seeing Paris.

They'll help us experience it.

For a few days, we'll have the opportunity to experience one of the world's great cities not simply as visitors, but through a slightly different lens.

And I think that's the best way to experience it.

### *Our Paris*

Now that we've talked about how to experience Paris, let's talk about “our Paris.”

Over the next four days, we'll visit some of the city's most iconic places. Some have stood for centuries. Others are surprisingly modern. Each tells part of the story of Paris.

More importantly, each gives us an opportunity to experience the city together.

Before we begin, I want to once again recognize our captain.

Every stop over the next four days—the neighborhoods we'll explore, the museums we'll visit, the walks between them, and even the moments we've intentionally left unscheduled—is the result of an incredible amount of thought and planning by Kate.

She has spent months charting our course through Paris, balancing the iconic places everyone dreams of seeing with quieter experiences that reveal the city's true character. I have a feeling that years from now, many of our favorite memories will trace back to the care she put into creating this adventure for all of us.

We'll begin our first full day at perhaps the most recognizable landmark in France.

The Eiffel Tower.

When it was completed for the 1889 World's Fair, many Parisians considered it an eyesore and expected it to be dismantled after only twenty years.

Instead, it became the symbol of Paris.

As you're standing beneath it, look up through the remarkable iron latticework stretching into the sky. It's difficult to appreciate just how enormous it is until you're directly underneath it.

The tower also has yet another connection that brings our two countries together.

Its designer, Gustave Eiffel, engineered the internal framework of the Statue of Liberty before constructing the tower that now bears his name. Two of the world's most recognizable landmarks, linked by one engineer and by the enduring friendship between France and the United States.



From there, we'll continue toward the Seine.

More than any monument, this river is the heart of Paris.

For centuries it has connected neighborhoods, carried commerce, inspired artists, and shaped everyday life.

We'll cross it on foot.

Admire it from its bridges.

And later, we'll experience it from the water itself on our evening cruise.

As you're standing along its banks, notice how naturally life gathers here.

People reading.

Friends sharing a picnic.

Musicians performing.

Couples strolling.

The Seine isn't simply something to look at.

It's where Paris lives.

Our walks will later bring us to Notre-Dame.

Construction began in 1163 during the great age of Gothic cathedrals. At the time, building something this tall and filling it with so much light seemed almost impossible. Through remarkable innovations like pointed arches, ribbed vaults, and flying buttresses, medieval builders discovered how to support soaring stone walls while replacing much of them with magnificent stained glass. It was one of the greatest engineering achievements of the Middle Ages.

As you gaze at its magnificent façade, remember that this cathedral has witnessed many defining moments in French history. Napoleon crowned himself Emperor here in 1804 with Pope Pius VII looking on. For almost nine centuries, kings, pilgrims, revolutionaries, artists, visitors from around the world, and ordinary Parisians have gathered before these same doors.

After surviving the devastating fire of 2019, its painstaking restoration reminds us that some places are simply too important to lose.

Just a short walk away is Sainte-Chapelle.

From the outside, it's easy to overlook.

Inside, it's unforgettable.

Its soaring stained-glass windows surround you with light in a way that almost feels unreal.

When you step inside, resist the temptation to immediately reach for your camera.

Spend a moment simply looking.

It's one of those rare places that photographs never quite capture.

We'll also spend time exploring the Louvre.

Of course we'll all want to see masterpieces like the *Mona Lisa*, the *Winged Victory of Samothrace*, and Delacroix's *Liberty Leading the People*, one of the defining images of French history.

But don't forget to admire the building itself.

Long before it became one of the world's greatest museums, it was the palace of French kings.

As you're walking through its courtyards, you're also walking through centuries of French history.

Our itinerary also includes the Musée d'Orsay, one of my favorite museums anywhere in the world.

Housed inside a magnificent former railway station overlooking the Seine, it tells a very different story than the Louvre. Rather than ancient civilizations and royal collections, Orsay celebrates the birth of modern art through masterpieces by Monet, Renoir, Degas, Van Gogh, and many others.

Even if you don't think of yourself as an art lover, I suspect you'll recognize far more paintings than you expect.

We'll spend time wandering through Le Marais, one of Paris's oldest and most interesting neighborhoods.

Its narrow streets, small shops, cafés, hidden courtyards, and lively squares remind us that Paris isn't simply a collection of monuments.

It's a collection of neighborhoods, each with its own personality.

Of course, no four days in Paris would be complete without experiencing its extraordinary food.

We'll enjoy everything from simple picnics with fresh sandwiches in the Luxembourg Gardens, to crêpes and street food as we wander between neighborhoods, to lively Parisian bistros serving

classics like steak frites, onion soup, and beautifully crafted sauces that remind us why French cuisine has influenced restaurants around the world.

We'll also have the opportunity to enjoy a memorable evening of refined French dining, celebrating not just exceptional food, but the joy of sharing a table together in one of the world's great culinary cities.

The wonderful thing is that all of those experiences are equally Parisian.

Sometimes the meal you'll remember most isn't the most elaborate one.

It's simply the one you shared with people you love.

We'll also have time built into the schedule simply to wander.

That isn't empty space.

It's intentional.

One of the luxuries we've tried to build into this itinerary is choice.

Not everyone has to see everything.

If there's somewhere you'd like to return...

A neighborhood you'd like to explore...

Or simply a café where you'd like to sit for a while...

That's time well spent.

For those looking for another adventure, there are several wonderful optional stops.

If you're looking for one optional stop, I'd give special consideration to the Musée de l'Orangerie.

It's much smaller than the Louvre, but it's home to Claude Monet's breathtaking *Water Lilies*, displayed in two oval rooms designed exactly as he envisioned them.

Kate took me there for the first time when we traveled to Paris together for the first time, and it remains one of my favorite memories of the city.

It wasn't crowded or hurried.

Just a quiet, beautiful place where we could slow down for a while.

If you're looking for a peaceful break from the energy of Paris, it's hard to imagine a better choice.

If you're in the mood for something completely different, the Catacombs offer a fascinating look beneath the streets of Paris.

Their tunnels contain the carefully arranged remains of more than six million Parisians, relocated there centuries ago when the city's cemeteries became overcrowded.

It's unusual.

A little eerie.

And unlike anything else we'll experience on the trip.

Or perhaps simply wander through Saint-Germain-des-Prés.

Its ancient church is the oldest in Paris, but the neighborhood is just as famous for its cafés, bookstores, and literary history.

It's exactly the kind of place where you can wander without a destination and still feel like you've discovered something special.

By the time we board the train for Provence, I hope each of us has found a favorite corner of Paris.

For some, it may be the Eiffel Tower.

For others, perhaps a quiet square.

A neighborhood café.

A bridge across the Seine.

A museum.

Or a street whose name we've already forgotten.

Because in the end, that's what Paris does so well.

It gives each visitor a different city.

And I have a feeling each of us will leave with our own Paris.

*Why Paris Endures*

There are many beautiful cities in the world.

Many great museums.

Many remarkable churches.

Many wonderful restaurants.

But somehow, Paris has become something more.

For centuries, artists, writers, musicians, architects, chefs, and dreamers have come here seeking inspiration.

Some stayed for a lifetime.

Others carried a little piece of Paris home with them.

Perhaps that's because Paris has found an extraordinary balance.

It honors its past without living in it.

It embraces beauty without feeling artificial.

It celebrates everyday life as much as grand occasions.

And somehow, it reminds us that slowing down, sharing a meal, taking a walk, or sitting beside a river can be just as meaningful as checking another famous landmark off a list.

Over the next few days, we'll see many of the places that have made Paris famous.

But I hope what we'll remember most won't simply be the monuments.

I hope we'll remember the conversations.

The laughter.

The meals we shared.

The little discoveries from our Paris Challenge.

And those unexpected moments that no itinerary could ever plan.

Because years from now, I doubt any of us will remember exactly what we did at two o'clock on a Tuesday afternoon.

But I think we'll remember how Paris made us feel.

And that's why people keep coming back.